

New EU Arctic strategy to release Oct. 20

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By Martina Sapio · Sep 9, 2026, 2:36 PM · [View in your browser](#)

BRUSSELS — European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen is set to present the EU's long-delayed new Arctic Strategy on Oct. 20, according to the College of Commissioners' new calendar .

Brussels has been working for months on an overhaul of the bloc's 2021 Arctic policy , which was written before Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine and before the region became an arena for military, economic and shipping competition.

The new strategy is expected to put security and defense more in focus, reflecting Russia's military build-up in the High North , China's growing commercial and strategic presence and NATO's stronger northern posture following the accession of Finland and Sweden.

The Arctic is also increasingly tied to Europe's economic security agenda, particularly around the mining of critical raw materials, energy and Greenland, where the EU has been deepening political and investment ties .

Shipping is likely to feature much more prominently than in 2021, as the Arctic warms at nearly four times the global average and retreating sea ice opens trade routes that were previously far harder to navigate.

In August, Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov hailed the arrival in Murmansk of a Chinese container ship that had travelled via an Arctic route as a "new phase," as Moscow continues to push for greater international use of its Northern Sea Route.

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